Data Classification Guide
WyIT.2001-G1

Policy Owner	Drew Dilly, Chief Data Officer
Policy Contact	Pat Potter, Deputy Chief Data Officer
Policy Approver	Jeff Clines, Chief Information Officer
Effective Date	September 12, 2025
Next Review Date	April 1, 2027
Policy Version	2026-09.01
Associated Policy	WyIT 2001, Information Classification

Introduction:

This guide supports Wyoming state agencies in properly classifying, protecting, and handling state information. This guide incorporates data domain concepts as a foundational element of effective information governance.

This standard applies to all Executive Branch agencies, boards, and commissions staff (collectively referred to as "agencies"). This standard is also applicable to consultants, affiliates, third party vendors and temporary employees that use or store data.

Authority

This guideline is promulgated under the authority of Wyoming State Statute 9-2-2906 and its subsections, the Department of Enterprise Technology Services is required to adopt and enforce information technology standards, and promote efficient use of information technology throughout state government.

Specifically, this policy is further promulgated under the authority of the below listed Wyoming State Statute subsections.

- Implements and maintains an information technology governance program for state agencies (W.S 9-2-2906,(b), (ii));
- Establishes and enforces data security and privacy policies and standards for the state data infrastructure Establishes review criteria for the agencies information technology projects, procurements and purchases. (W.S 9-2-2906,(b), (iii)); and

Adopts information technology policies and standards and ensures agency compliance with those policies and standards (W.S. 9-2-2906,(b), (vi)).

Audience

This policy applies to all Executive Branch agencies, boards, and commissions staff (collectively referred to as "agencies"). This policy is also applicable to consultants, affiliates, third party vendors and temporary employees that use or store state data.

Definitions

Key Definitions, Acronyms, and Terms

Data Classification Levels:

- **Public (Low Sensitivity)**
    - Information that poses no risk to the State if made generally available.
    - This includes information intended for public release or already publicly available.
    - Example data types: press releases, public meeting minutes, published reports, agency contact information, public-facing website content.
- **Internal (Moderate Sensitivity)**:
    - Information whose loss, corruption, or unauthorized disclosure is of importance only inside the State and, therefore, would not result in a tangible business, financial, or legal loss.
    - This information is not routinely shared outside the State government but is generally accessible to State employees.
- **Confidential (High Sensitivity)**:
    - Information whose loss, corruption, or unauthorized disclosure would seriously harm an individual's, business's, or the State's reputation or business position, resulting in severe financial and legal loss.
    - Confidential information is subject to controlled access and special handling requirements.
        - **Confidential-Standard**: Sensitive business or operational information
        - **Confidential-Regulated**: Information subject to specific regulatory requirements

Other Key Concepts

- **Classification Inheritance**
    - The process by which compiled or derivative information takes on the highest classification level of any component information.
    - When information consists of elements with different classification levels, the entire information asset shall be classified at the highest level of any component element.

- **Aggregated Data**
    - Collections of data elements from multiple sources that may require higher classification than individual elements due to revealing patterns or sensitive insights when combined.
    - Agencies must consider whether aggregated data requires higher classification than its component parts due to mosaic effects or inference risks.

Detailed Classification System:

1. PUBLIC (LOW SENSITIVITY) INFORMATION

1.1. Public (low sensitivity) information is information that poses no risk to the State, if made generally available. This type of information is typically either Unrestricted or Available Upon Request.

1.2. Unrestricted:

1.2.1. Information that is public knowledge or readily available to the public.

1.2.2. May be disclosed in the normal course of conversation or other methods of communication without regard to whom the communication occurs.

1.3. Available Upon Request

1.3.1. Information readily available to the public but requires a formal request either in written form or in person.

1.3.2. Personnel should verify that the request is reasonable based on the Wyoming Public Records Act (WPRA).

1.3.3. Example types: employee names and direct telephone numbers, general or generic information about the organization, public meeting minutes.

1.4. Typically, the handling requirements for this type of information:

1.4.1. May be freely distributed without restrictions, in accordance with W.S. §16-4-202.

1.4.2. May be published on internet websites available to all internet users.

1.4.3. Have no special security measures required beyond normal good practices.

1.4.4. Should still be reviewed for accuracy before public release.

2. INTERNAL (MODERATE SENSITIVITY) INFORMATION

2.1. Examples may include, but are not limited to:

2.1.1. Internal Memos

2.1.2. Project Plans

2.1.3. Non-sensitive Internal Communications

2.1.4. Draft Documents

2.1.5. General Operating Procedures

2.1.6. General Employee Directories

2.1.7. Non-sensitive Meeting Notes

2.1.8. Routine Administrative Information

2.2. Typically, the handling requirements for this type of information:

2.2.1. Should be kept within state organization

2.2.2. May be shared between agencies but not with external parties without approval

2.2.3. Requires basic access controls to ensure only authorized state personnel can access.

2.2.4. May be included in agency intranets and areas of internet websites that require users to log in.

2.2.5. Should be labeled as “internal” where practical

2.2.6. Should be stored in systems with appropriate security controls.

3. CONFIDENTIAL (HIGH SENSITIVITY)

3.1. Confidential (high sensitivity) is information whose loss, corruption, or unauthorized disclosure would seriously harm an individual's, business's, or the State's reputation or business position, resulting in severe financial and legal loss.

3.2. Confidential-Standard information is sensitive business or operational information.

3.2.1. Example data types: security plans, sensitive strategic plans, contract negotiations, legal opinions, processing volumes, service pricing, equipment configurations, vendor information, application software configurations, and other similar business and technical information.

3.2.2. Confidential-Regulated information is information subject to specific regulatory requirements and requires strict control due to legal and regulatory mandates.

3.2.2.1. Example data types

3.2.2.1.1. Personally Identifiable Information (PII)

3.2.2.1.2. Protected Health Information (PHI)

3.2.2.1.3. Federal Tax Information (FTI)

3.2.2.1.4. Criminal Justice Information (CJI)

3.2.2.1.5. Payment Card Data

3.2.2.1.6. Employee private information (home address, telephone number, years of service, etc.); and

3.2.2.1.7. Customer information (names, contacts, addresses, etc.)

3.2.3. The handling requirements for this type of information includes:

3.2.3.1. Strict control requirement;.

3.2.3.2. Access on a need-to-know basis only;

3.2.3.3. Encryption for storage and transmission;

3.2.3.4. Written approval is needed for any external disclosure, in compliance with W.S. §16-4-203 and applicable federal laws;

3.2.3.5. Never published on any Internet Website;

3.2.3.6. Clear labeling as "Confidential" required;

3.2.3.7. Should be stored in secured systems with robust access controls; and

3.2.3.8. Transfer and sharing subject to additional restrictions

4. DATA DOMAINS

4.1. Data domains are logical groupings of related data that share common characteristics, serve similar business functions, or support specific program areas within an organization. They represent distinct categories of information that an agency manages and uses to fulfill its mission.

5. ALIGN DATA DOMAINS WITH ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE AND FUNCTIONS

5.1. Identify domains based on major program areas within your agency.

5.2. Ensure domains reflect the primary functions and services your agency provides.

5.2.1. Example: A health department might have domains for vital records, disease surveillance, provider licensing, and public health education.

6. ACCESS DATA CLASSIFICATION AND SENSITIVITY

6.1. Use Wyoming's three-tier classification system to group data with similar sensitivity levels.

6.2. Group data with similar protection requirements to streamline security controls.

6.2.1. Example: Group all data containing personally identifiable information (PII) that requires similar protection.

7. CONSIDER REGULATORY AND COMPLIANCE FACTORS

7.1. Identify data subject to specific regulations or statutes.

7.2. Group data that shares compliance requirements.

7.2.1. Example: Create a domain for all data subject to HIPAA regulations in a healthcare agency.

8. ANALYZE DATA RELATIONSHIPS AND DEPENDENCIES

8.1. Map how data flows between systems and stakeholders.

8.2. Identify relationships between different types of data

8.2.1. Example: Customer contact information used across multiple programs should be managed as a single domain.

9. EVALUATE DATA LIFECYCLE CONSIDERATIONS

9.1. Group data with similar retention schedules.

9.2. Consider how data is created, updated, archived, and destroyed

9.2.1. Example: Group financial records that must be retained for 7 years

10. ASSESS OPERATIONAL MANAGEMENT FACTORS

10.1. Identify natural groupings based on who manages the data.

10.2. Consider who needs access to the data and how it's used

10.2.1. Example: Create a domain for all GIS data that requires specialized knowledge and tools

11. DATA DOMAINS AND CLASSIFICATION SUPPORT

11.1. Establish clear lines of responsibility for data classification.

11.2. Enable designation of specific data stewards responsible for classification.

11.3. Create clear accountability for data quality, security, and compliance.

12. ENHANCED DATA QUALITY AND CONSISTENCY

12.1. Allow for consistent classification across similar data types.

12.2. Facilitate implementation of appropriate quality measures for each domain.

12.3. Reduce redundancy and conflicting classification decisions.

13. OPTIMIZED SECURITY CONTROLS

13.1. Enable right-sized security controls based on domain sensitivity.

13.2. Facilitate better risk assessment and mitigation strategies.

13.3. Streamline compliance with relevant regulations.

14. BETTER DATA SHARING AND INTEGRATION

14.1. Enable appropriate sharing within and across agencies.

14.2. Define clear boundaries for what data can be shared, with whom, and under what conditions.

14.3. Facilitate data integration between systems and agencies

Data Domain Example and Documentation Template:

Example Data Domains for a Wyoming State Agency

Domain Name	Description	Classification Level	Primary Systems	Data Owner
Vital Records	Birth, death, and marriage records	Confidential-Regulated	Vital Records System	Vital Records Program Manager
Financial Data	Budget, accounting, and procurement records	Internal	Financial Management System	Chief Financial Officer
Public Health Statistics	Aggregated, de-identified health trend data	Public	Health Statistics Database	State Epidemiologist
Employee Records	Personnel files, payroll, and benefits information	Confidential-Standard	HR Management System	Human Resources Director

Domain Name	Description	Classification Level	Primary Systems	Data Owner
Licensing Data	Professional and business licenses	Internal/Confidential*	Licensing Database	Licensing Division Manager

*Note: Basic license status information is Internal while detailed application materials may be Confidential

Data Domain Documentation Template

When documenting your data domains, consider using the following template:

Domain Attribute	Description
Domain Name	Clear, descriptive title for the domain
Description	Summary of the data contained in this domain
Data Types	List of major data types/categories included
Classification Level	Public, Internal, or Confidential per WyIT-2001
Data Owner	Individual accountable for the domain
Data Steward(s)	Individual(s) responsible for day-to-day management
Related Systems	Information systems that create or store this data
Regulatory Requirements	Applicable laws, regulations, or policies
Retention Period	How long data must be kept
Sharing Restrictions	Limitations on how data can be shared

Applicable State Policies, Federal, State or Industry Rules, Laws, and/or Regulations

1. National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) SP 800-53, Rev 5
2. National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) SP 800-60
3. National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) SP 800-122
4. Federal Privacy Act of 1974: 5 U.S.C. § 552a
5. WyIT 2001, Information Classification
6. WyIT 2001-S1, Data Owner Standard
7. WyIT 2001-S2, Data Steward Standard
8. WyIT 2001-S3, Data Custodian Standard
9. WyIT 2001-S4, Data Domain Standard
10. WyIT 2001-GL2, Information Classification Procedures Guide
11. WyIT-2004, Information Breach, Disclosure or Data Leak
12. WyIT 2004-GL, Information Breach Response Guide
13. WyIT-2005, Information Residency and Transportation
14. WyIT-2006, Agency Official for Privacy (AOP)
15. WyIT-2011, Wyoming State Data Collection, Transparency, and Consent

16. WyIT-2013, Electronic Data Destruction and Sanitization
17. WyIT 2014, Data Sharing Agreement Documentation and Governance

Compliance & Exceptions:

Compliance
This document supports an established policy, so there are no compliance requirements.

Exceptions
Since standards are not held to a compliance standard, there are no exceptions to this standard.

Review/Approval:

Date Issued/Review Date
This policy shall be reviewed at least annually and updated / reviewed / approved as defined in the Office of Chief Information Officer (OCIO) Policy lifecycle.

The review and update process shall be coordinated by Governance, Risk and Compliance (GRC), completed by the policy owner and approved through the OCIO policy review workflow.

Approval
This policy as signed by the appropriate officer (listed below) is considered approved and enforced, per Wyoming State Statutes (W.S 9-2-2906,(b), (iii)) and (W.S. 9-2-2906,(b), (vi)).

To obtain a signed copy of this document, contact Enterprise Technology Services Governance, Risk and Compliance (ets-ocio-grc@wyo.gov).

Jeffrey Clines Officer Name	Chief Information Officer Officer Title
_____ Officer's Signature	_____ Date

Revision History
The current version of this policy, as identified in the Revision History below, supersedes all previous documents listed below.

Version	Change	Author(s)	Date of Change
2026-09.1	ETS Director signature	GRC	September 2026
2025-09.01	WyIT 2001-G1, Information Classification Guide, Updated Document Template	Pat Potter Deputy CDO	September 2025

October 2022	WyIT 2001-GL, Information Classification Guideline Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S1, Data Owner Standard ● WyIT 2001-S2, Data Steward Standard ● WyIT 2001-S3, Data Custodian ● WyIT 2001-S4, Data Domain Standard	Wyoming Data Governance Committee	August 2024
UKN	WyIT 2001-S, Information Classification Standard Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S1, Data Owner Standard ● WyIT 2001-S2, Data Steward Standard ● WyIT 2001-S3, Data Custodian ● WyIT 2001-S4, Data Domain Standard	Wyoming Data Governance Committee	August 2024
UKN	08100-P131, Policy Information Classification Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S, Information Classification Standard ● WyIT 2001-GL, Information Classification Guideline	UKN	November 2018
UKN	08100-S131, Information Classification Standard Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S, Information Classification Standard ● WyIT 2001-GL, Information Classification Guideline	UKN	May 2018